

Checkmate Without Stalemate

Cover the escape squares, protect the checking piece, and verify the final position.

WHO THIS BOOK IS FOR

Players who know how the pieces move and want to make better decisions. Use a board if notation is new. Books 01-08 need no endgame theory; read Book 09 before the more demanding rook examples in Book 10.

THREE LESSONS. EACH HAS A MODEL, AN EXERCISE AND AN EXPLAINED ANSWER.

01 Queen and king close the cage

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02 The king must help the rook

P. 6

03 No legal move is not always mate

P. 9

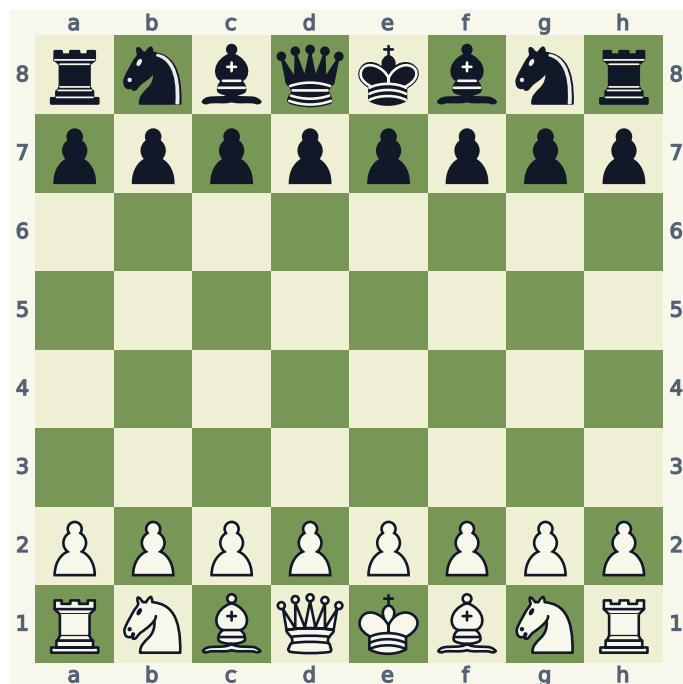
A practical study session

Spend 5 minutes reading the model, 5 minutes solving without the answer, and 5 minutes explaining the solution aloud. Spend another 5 minutes playing the position from both sides. Study one lesson per day; repeat its exercise tomorrow and a week later.

What counts as learning: name the relevant fact, show the opponent's reply, and explain what remains. A move guessed without a reason earns only partial credit. The goal is a repeatable decision, not a memorized diagram.

Use the board, then the move list

Every diagram says who moves. Boards face that player; file letters and rank numbers remain authoritative.



NOTATION YOU WILL SEE

1. K = king, Q = queen, R = rook, B = bishop, N = knight. A pawn move has no piece letter.
2. Nf3 means a knight moves to f3. Rxc6 means a rook captures on c6.
3. + means check; # means checkmate. O-O means kingside castling. e8=Q means promotion to a queen.
4. 1... means Black moves first in that line. Read one move, make it on a board, then read the reply.

THE SAME THINKING ROUTINE IN EVERY CHAPTER

1. Check the immediate threat.
2. List two sensible candidates.
3. Test the opponent's checks, captures and threats.
4. Inspect the final board: material, king safety, piece activity and pawn structure.

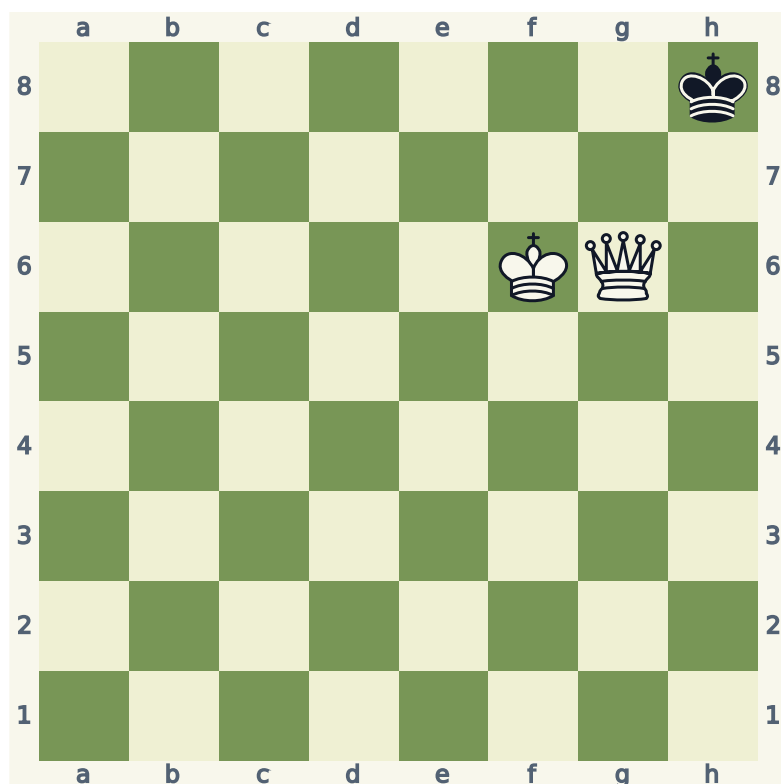
Read the claim carefully. A sample line may illustrate a plan without forcing every reply. Some exercises ask for a safe move, a legal move or a correct diagnosis rather than a unique best move. A tablebase gives an exact result for the specified small ending; an engine check supports a line but is not a proof of every strategic claim.

Replay and revisit. The web edition includes every explanation. Download its PGN file to load the model and exercise positions into a chess program; each starts from a FEN position code. No account or software is needed to read the PDF or website.

Queen and king close the cage

A queen can cover many escape squares, but a close-range mating queen often needs the king's protection. Prove mate by checking the defender's complete set of replies.

MODEL A / WHITE TO MOVE



READ THESE FACTS FIRST

1. Black's king is on h8 at the edge of the board.
2. White's king on f6 protects g7.
3. The queen can move from g6 to g7 without crossing another piece.

WORKED SEQUENCE

1. Qg7#

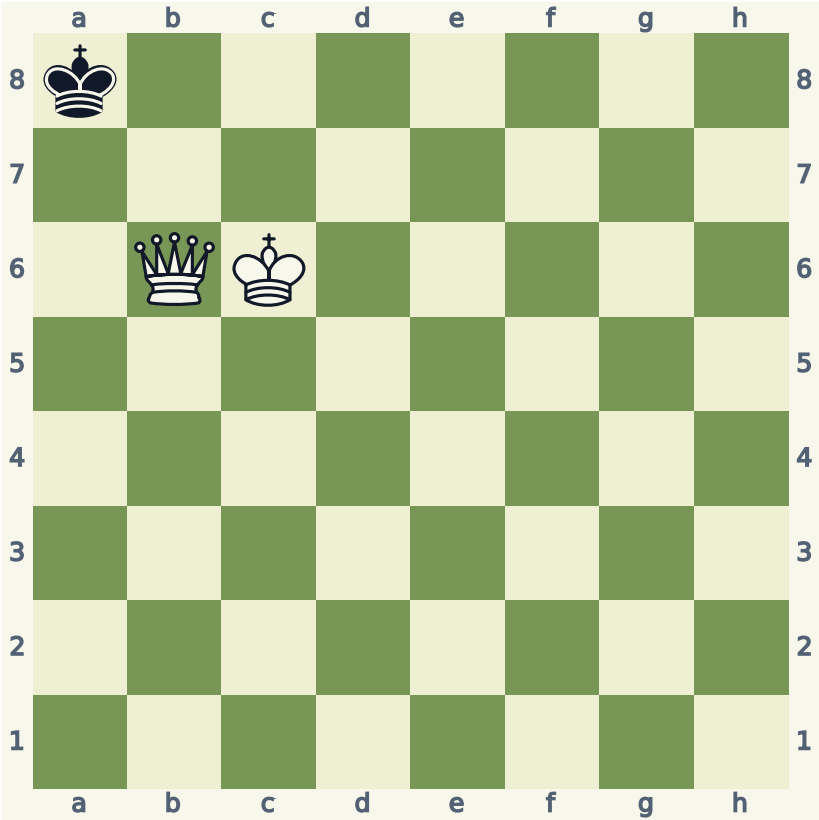
Qg7# places the queen next to the king with protection. The queen checks along g7-h8 and covers h7 and g8. The black king cannot capture the queen on g7 because White's king attacks that square.

There is no piece available to capture or block the check. The position is mate because the king is in check and has no legal response. Verify those two facts separately; merely trapping a king can also produce stalemate.

Your turn: inspect the changed position

Work for five minutes before turning the page. Write the reason and the opponent's reply, even if you recognize the pattern.

EXERCISE B / WHITE TO MOVE



- 1. Find the matching mating move on the other side of the board.
- 2. Why can Black not capture the queen?
- 3. Which squares around a8 does the queen cover?

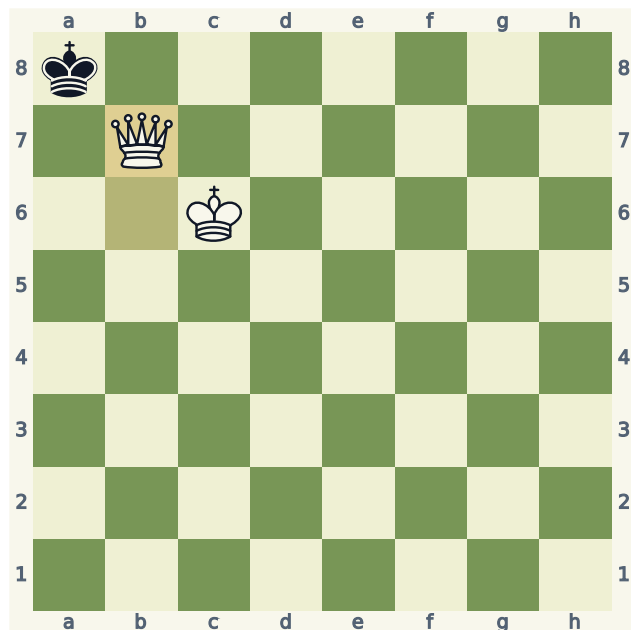
MY CANDIDATE, THE REPLY I EXPECT, AND THE REASON

Position code (FEN): k7/8/1QK5/8/8/8/8 w - - 0 1

Check your reasoning

1. Qb7#

EXERCISE B / AFTER THE SAMPLE LINE



1. Qb7# mirrors the model. The queen moves from b6 to b7 and checks the king on a8 diagonally.
2. White's king on c6 protects b7. Capturing the queen would move Black's king into an attacked square.
3. The queen covers a7, b8 and its own defended square b7. Those are all three on-board neighboring squares available from a8. The king is in check, so no legal move means mate.

WHERE THE IDEA CAN FAIL

An unprotected queen placed next to the enemy king may simply be captured. Always name the piece protecting the mating queen, even when the pattern looks familiar.

TRANSFER TO YOUR OWN GAMES

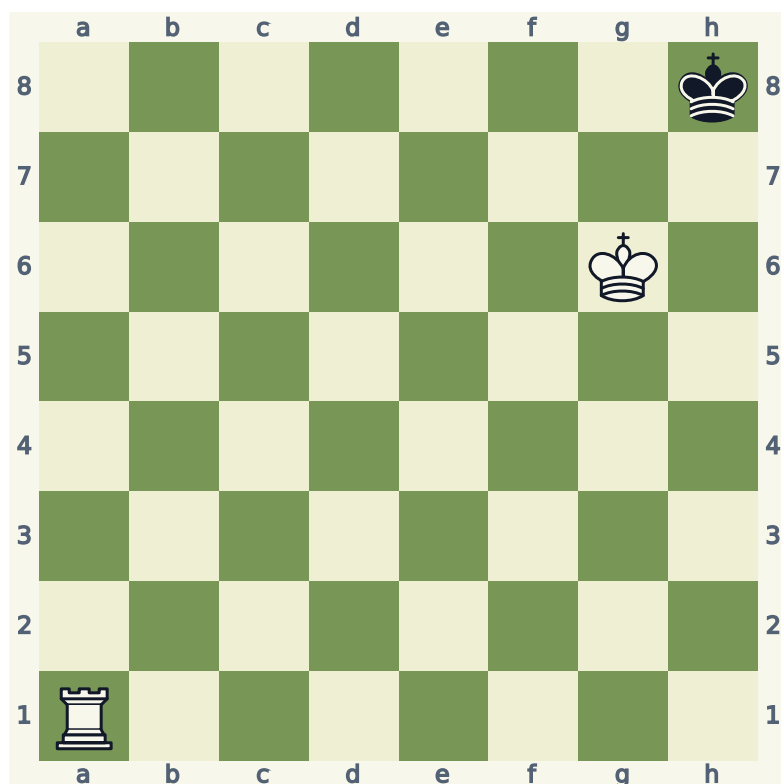
Rebuild both positions from memory. For each mating move, point to every neighboring square of the losing king and explain why it cannot move there.

Score your explanation: give 1 point for the relevant fact and 1 for the consequence in each of the three answers (6 total). At 4 or below, replay the model and try again tomorrow. A different legal plan can earn full credit when it satisfies the question and survives the opponent's reply.

The king must help the rook

The rook cuts a rank or file, while the king controls the escape squares beyond that line. Rook mate is a coordination task, not a sequence of random checks.

MODEL A / WHITE TO MOVE



READ THESE FACTS FIRST

1. White's king on g6 controls f7, g7 and h7.
2. The rook can reach a8 along the clear a-file.
3. A rook on a8 would check across the eighth rank.

WORKED SEQUENCE

1. Ra8#

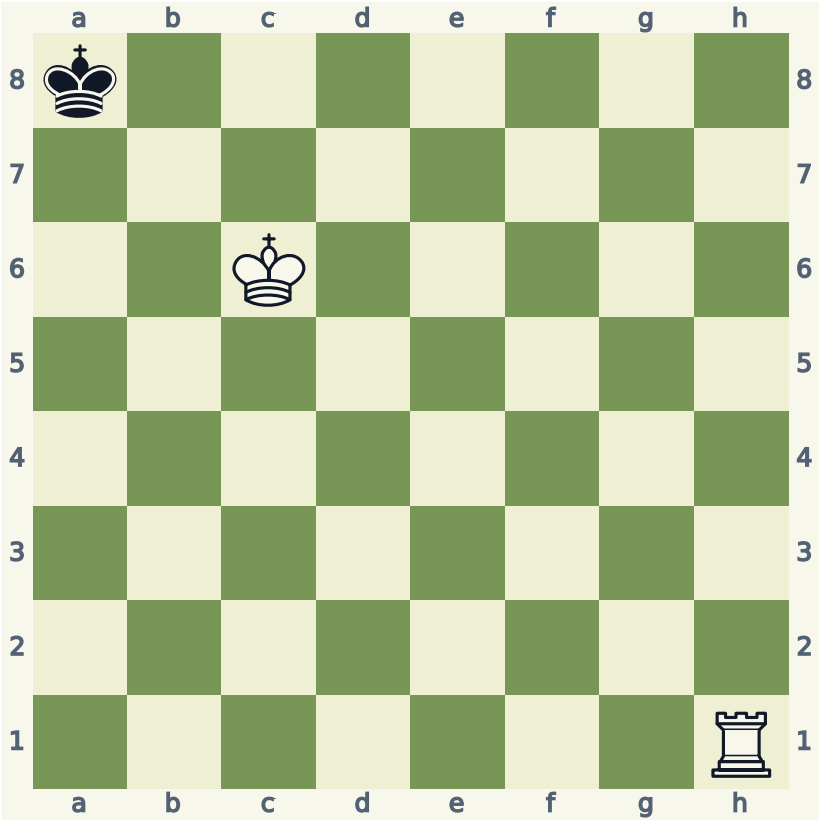
Ra8# checks the king on h8. The rook covers g8, and White's king covers g7 and h7. Black has no piece that can block the rook's line or capture it.

The king does the work that the rook cannot: it controls the row of escape squares below the checking rank. If the white king were farther away, the same rook check could let the defender escape instead of ending the game.

Your turn: inspect the changed position

Work for five minutes before turning the page. Write the reason and the opponent's reply, even if you recognize the pattern.

EXERCISE B / WHITE TO MOVE



- 1. Why does Rh8+ immediately fail to mate?
- 2. What king move prepares the mating net?
- 3. After the forced king reply, give the mate and explain the division of work.

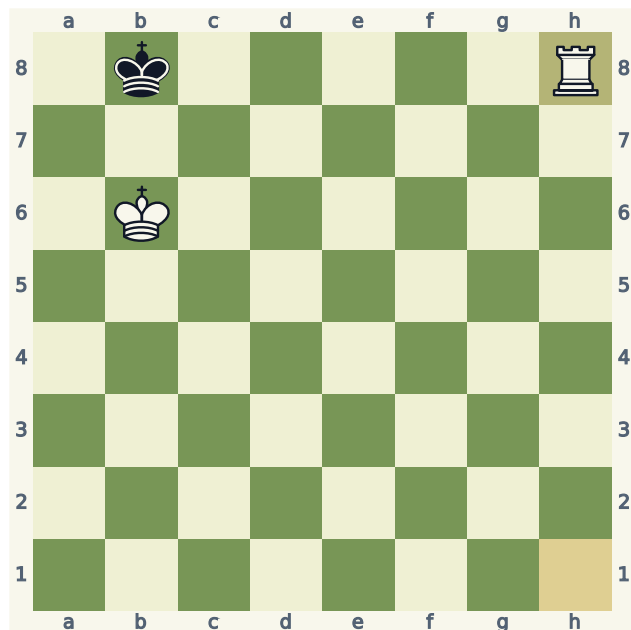
MY CANDIDATE, THE REPLY I EXPECT, AND THE REASON

Position code (FEN): k7/8/2K5/8/8/8/8/7R w - - 0 1

Check your reasoning

1. Kb6 Kb8 2. Rh8#

EXERCISE B / AFTER THE SAMPLE LINE



1. After Rh8+, Black can play ...Ka7. White's king on c6 does not attack a7, so the defender can leave the back rank.

2. Kb6 controls a7 and b7. Black then has only ...Kb8: a7 is attacked by the king and b7 is also attacked.

3. Rh8# now checks along the eighth rank. The rook controls a8 and c8, while the king on b6 controls a7, b7 and c7. The mating net is complete because king and rook cover different escape routes.

WHERE THE IDEA CAN FAIL

Do not give the final rook check before your king controls the exit. A check can release the opposing king from the edge if you have not completed the cage.

TRANSFER TO YOUR OWN GAMES

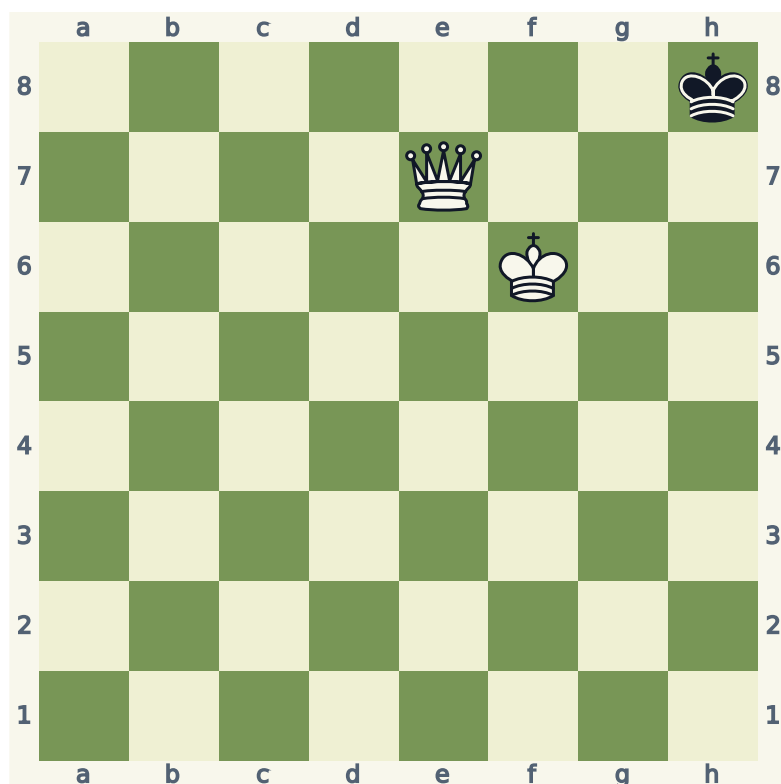
Place the defending king on a different edge square. Before checking with the rook, mark the escape row and move your king to control it.

Score your explanation: give 1 point for the relevant fact and 1 for the consequence in each of the three answers (6 total). At 4 or below, replay the model and try again tomorrow. A different legal plan can earn full credit when it satisfies the question and survives the opponent's reply.

No legal move is not always mate

Checkmate requires check. Stalemate occurs when the player to move is not in check but has no legal move; it ends the game as a draw.

MODEL A / WHITE TO MOVE



READ THESE FACTS FIRST

1. Black's king on h8 has only three neighboring squares on the board.
2. Qg7 gives check and is protected by White's king.
3. Qf7 covers the exits without attacking h8.

WORKED SEQUENCE

1. Qg7#

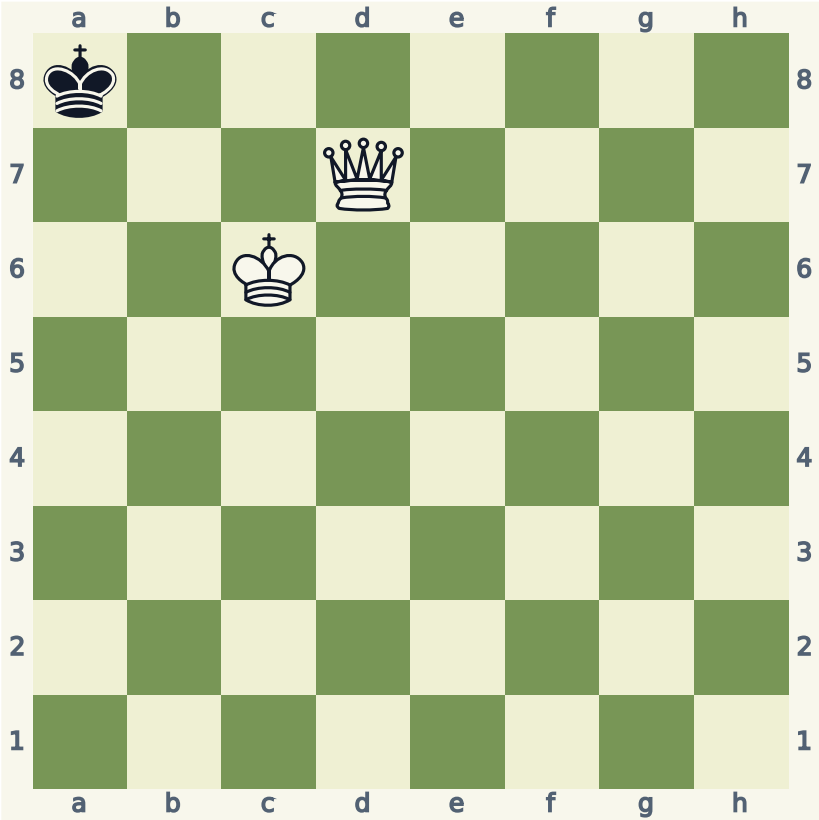
Qg7# wins for the same reason as the first lesson: it checks, covers the exits and cannot be captured. Verify that the move attacks the king itself, not just the surrounding squares.

Compare Qf7?. The queen covers g8, g7 and h7, so Black has no move. But h8 is not attacked. With no other black pieces or pawns to move, the result is stalemate. A huge material advantage does not override that rule.

Your turn: inspect the changed position

Work for five minutes before turning the page. Write the reason and the opponent's reply, even if you recognize the pattern.

EXERCISE B / WHITE TO MOVE



- 1. Find a mating move from this new queen square.
- 2. What is wrong with Qc7?
- 3. Explain the result of each move using the two required facts.

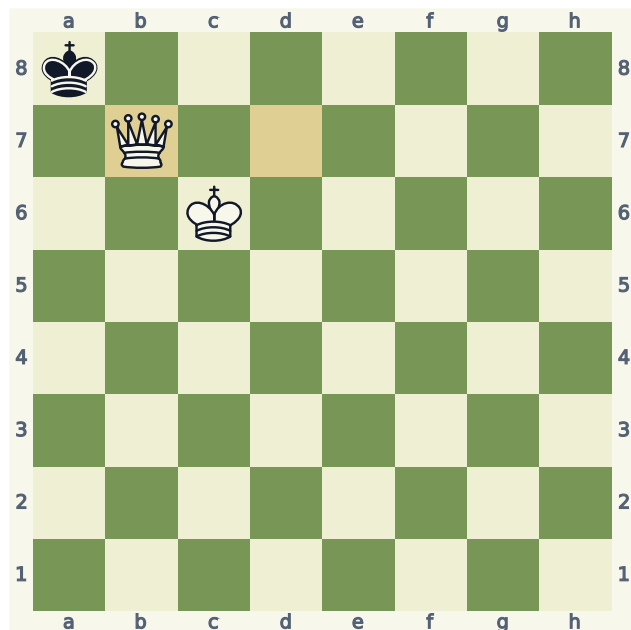
MY CANDIDATE, THE REPLY I EXPECT, AND THE REASON

Position code (FEN): k7/3Q4/2K5/8/8/8/8 w - - 0 1

Check your reasoning

1. Qb7#

EXERCISE B / AFTER THE SAMPLE LINE



1. Qb7# is mate. The queen attacks a8 and is protected on b7 by the king on c6.

2. Qc7 produces stalemate. It covers a7 along the seventh rank, b8 diagonally and b7 along the rank, but does not attack a8.

3. After Qb7, Black is in check and has no legal reply: mate. After Qc7, Black is not in check and has no legal move: draw by stalemate. The absence of a legal move alone does not tell you which result applies.

WHERE THE IDEA CAN FAIL

Near a bare king, every quiet queen move deserves a stalemate check. Ask "Is the king in check?" before asking "Can the king move?"

TRANSFER TO YOUR OWN GAMES

Set up a queen-versus-king ending. For each candidate move, label the resulting position "check," "mate," "stalemate," or "none" before moving on the board.

Score your explanation: give 1 point for the relevant fact and 1 for the consequence in each of the three answers (6 total). At 4 or below, replay the model and try again tomorrow. A different legal plan can earn full credit when it satisfies the question and survives the opponent's reply.

Remember it without the diagram

CLOSE THE BOOK. ANSWER THESE THREE QUESTIONS FROM MEMORY.

1. What protects the queen in Qg7#?
2. What should the king do before the final rook check?
3. What single condition distinguishes mate from stalemate when no legal move exists?

CHECK YOUR ANSWERS AFTER YOU HAVE TRIED

1. The white king on f6 protects g7.
2. Control the escape squares beyond the rook's checking rank or file.
3. Whether the side to move is in check: yes means mate; no means stalemate.

Checking and scope. Original teaching positions and explanations, with standard opening sequences where indicated. All 6 starting positions and listed moves in this book were checked for legality. Stockfish 19 reviewed candidates at depth 18; available positions with 7 or fewer pieces were also checked against the Lichess tablebase. Strategic examples do not claim unique best play. These AI-assisted materials are not a substitute for checking an unfamiliar continuation on a board.

PRIMARY REFERENCES AND FURTHER PRACTICE

[Lichess practice: tactics and endgames](#)

[Lichess opposition practice](#)

[Lichess basic rook endgames](#)

[Stockfish: official engine](#)

[Lichess tablebase API](#)

Edition 1.0 | 2026-09-10 | Lesson text: 1d42c4. Chess piece artwork: Colin M. L. Burnett (Cburnett), GPLv2+. Full artwork source, credits, position data and validation notes are in the repository. Report a correction with the book, lesson ID and exact move.